

Structured Knowledge Base: DBT Crisis Intervention and Skill Protocols (RAG-Optimized)

1. Knowledge Base Framework and RAG Integration Strategy

This structured knowledge base is engineered to serve as the core intelligence layer for a Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) system specialized in Dialectical Behavior Therapy (DBT). By organizing clinical protocols into a four-fold schema—**[Topic]**, **[Trigger Symptoms]**, **[Clinical Guidance]**, and **[Therapist Dialogue]**—we enable the system to perform high-precision semantic mapping between a user's raw distress signals and validated therapeutic interventions. The **[Trigger Symptoms]** are keyword-dense to maximize cosine similarity during vector search, while the **[Clinical Guidance]** and **[Therapist Dialogue]** provide the LLM with structured "instructions" and "voice" to ensure safety and clinical fidelity.

Tone and Style Guidelines

- **Clinical Guidance:** During high-arousal states, individuals experience "cognitive narrowing," which severely limits information processing. All guidance must use simple, low-literacy language, avoiding complex jargon. Instructions should be delivered as brief, step-by-step actions.
- **Therapist Dialogue:** Adhering to DBT General Handout 5, the dialogue must be warm, non-judgmental, and deeply validating. It must move beyond robotic clinical observation to sound like a compassionate human presence, prioritizing Level 4 (Understanding) and Level 5 (Acknowledging the Valid) validation.

The following modules move from immediate physiological stabilization to long-term emotional resilience.

2. Module I: Crisis Survival Skills (Distress Tolerance)

Distress Tolerance skills are the primary "entry points" for a user in a 10/10 emotional state. The goal is not to solve the underlying problem immediately, but to survive the crisis without making it worse. When a user is "hit by a ton of bricks," these skills provide the necessary physiological "circuit breaker."

TIPP Skills: Rapid Body Chemistry Change

- **[Topic]:** TIPP Skills: Rapid Body Chemistry Change.
- **[Trigger Symptoms]:** Emotional 10/10, "about to explode," physical agitation, racing heart, sweating, urge to self-harm, "hit by a ton of bricks," "I can't breathe," "everything is too much," "breaking point."
- **[Clinical Guidance]:**
 - **Temperature:** Hold your breath and submerge your face in a bowl of very cold water, or apply a cold pack/ice to your eyes and cheeks for 30 seconds. This triggers the mammalian dive reflex to immediately slow your heart rate.
 - **Intense Exercise:** Engage in high-intensity activity (jumping jacks, sprinting, fast walking) for a short while (20 minutes) to expend physical energy.
 - **Paced Breathing:** Slow your pace of breathing. Breathe in for 4 seconds, breathe out for 6 seconds. Make the exhale longer than the inhale.
 - **Paired Muscle Relaxation:** While breathing in, tense your muscles as hard as you can. While breathing out, say the word "Relax" in your mind and let the tension go completely.
- **[Therapist Dialogue]:** "I can feel how much you're hurting right now, and I'm right here with you. It feels like things are moving too fast to handle. Let's try something to help your body feel a little calmer. If you can, try to hold your breath and put something very cold on your eyes and cheeks for just 30 seconds. It's a way to tell your heart to slow down so we can get through this minute together."

STOP Skill: Stopping Impulsive Behavior

- **[Topic]:** STOP Skill: Stopping Impulsive Behavior.
- **[Trigger Symptoms]:** Impulsive urges, acting without thinking, "out of control," about to say something I'll regret, "I can't stop myself," feeling "reactive."
- **[Clinical Guidance]:**

- **Stop:** Don't move a muscle. Freeze! Your feelings may be trying to make you act without thinking.
- **Take a step back:** Take a break from the situation. Take a deep breath. Don't let your feelings guide your movements.
- **Observe:** Notice what is going on inside and outside you. What are the facts? What are you thinking and feeling?
- **Proceed mindfully:** Ask your Wise Mind: "Which action will make this better or worse?"
- **[Therapist Dialogue]:** "I notice you're feeling a really strong urge to react right now. Before you do anything else, let's just pause for one second. Just freeze. Take a step back and just breathe with me. We don't have to fix the whole problem this moment; let's just stay in this pause together until you feel like you can choose your next move mindfully."

Physiological stabilization via TIPP and STOP creates the mental space required for the cognitive centering found in Mindfulness.

3. Module II: Core Mindfulness and Centering

Mindfulness is the foundation of the DBT framework. It moves the user from the "hot" Emotion Mind or the "cold" Reasonable Mind into **Wise Mind**—the synthesis of reason and emotion. In this module, "What" skills represent the specific actions the user takes, while "How" skills represent the quality and way in which those actions are performed.

Wise Mind: Accessing Inner Wisdom

- **[Topic]:** Wise Mind: Accessing Inner Wisdom.
- **[Trigger Symptoms]:** "Frazzled," "overwhelmed," trapped in "hot" anger/fear, or stuck in "cold" logic, "I don't know what to do," "I feel split."
- **[Clinical Guidance]:**
 - **Stone Flake on the Lake:** Imagine you are a small, flat flake of stone tossed onto a clear blue lake. Imagine yourself slowly, gently floating through the calm water toward the smooth, sandy bottom. Settle your attention there, in your center.

- **Spiral Stairs:** Imagine a spiral staircase inside you. Walk down the stairs slowly, going deeper into your center. Notice the quiet and settle your attention at the bottom, perhaps in your solar plexus.
- **[Therapist Dialogue]:** "Let's take a moment to find that quiet place inside you. Imagine you are like a stone flake, gently floating down through a very still, clear lake. There's no rush at all. As you settle onto the bottom, just notice the calmness that lives deep within you. That wisdom is always there, even when the surface feels choppy. Let's just sit with that quiet for a moment."

Observe and Describe: Sticking to the Facts

- **[Topic]:** Observe and Describe Skills: Sticking to the Facts.
- **[Trigger Symptoms]:** Judgmental thoughts ("This is awful," "I'm a failure"), "round and round" worries, feeling out of touch with reality, "catastrophizing."
- **[Clinical Guidance]:**
 - **What Skill - Observe:** Just notice the experience through your senses. Use "wordless watching." Watch thoughts drift by like clouds without pushing them away or clinging to them.
 - **What Skill - Describe:** Put words on the experience. Use only factual language. Avoid "good," "bad," "fair," or "unfair."
 - **How Skill - Nonjudgmentally:** Unglue your opinions from the facts. Instead of saying "He was mean," say "He raised his voice."
- **[Therapist Dialogue]:** "I hear that you're having the thought that 'everything is a mess.' It makes sense that you feel overwhelmed by that. Let's try to unglue that thought from the facts for a second. Can you tell me just one thing you can see or hear right now? Maybe it's the sound of a fan or the feel of the chair. Just the facts, without the 'good' or the 'bad' attached to them."

Once the mind is centered and grounded in facts, the user can navigate the complexities of social interaction.

4. Module III: Interpersonal Effectiveness and Boundary Setting

The strategic goal here is to balance three needs: Obtaining an objective, maintaining the relationship, and preserving self-respect.

DEAR MAN: Getting Your Needs Met

- **[Topic]:** DEAR MAN Skill: Getting Your Needs Met.
- **[Trigger Symptoms]:** Loneliness, conflict, "no one listens to me," "I can't say no," "I feel ignored," "I need to ask for a favor but I'm scared."
- **[Clinical Guidance]:**
 - **Describe:** State the facts of the situation clearly.
 - **Express:** Use "I" statements ("I feel," "I want").
 - **Assert:** Ask clearly for what you want or say "No."
 - **Reinforce:** Explain why this helps both of you.
 - **Mindful:** Stay focused; use "Broken Record" if needed.
 - **Appear Confident:** Use a steady tone and eye contact.
 - **Negotiate:** Be willing to "give to get."

Letter	Skill	"Do This" Instruction
D	Describe	Stick to the facts. "You said you would be here at 8, and it is now 9."
E	Express	Use "I" statements. "I feel worried when you are late."
A	Assert	Ask or say no clearly. "I would like you to call if you are late."
R	Reinforce	Reward the person. "I'll be much easier to be around if I'm not worried."

- **[Therapist Dialogue]:** "It sounds like you have something really important to ask for, and it makes total sense that you want to be heard. I can see why this situation is frustrating. Let's try to put it into words together: 'The facts are [Situation]. I feel [Emotion] about it. I would like [Specific Request]. It would help us both because [Reinforcement].' How does it feel to say that out loud?"

FAST Skill: Maintaining Self-Respect

- **[Topic]:** FAST Skill: Maintaining Self-Respect.
- **[Trigger Symptoms]:** Feeling ashamed after talking, "selling out" integrity to be liked, over-apologizing, "I feel like a doormat," "I'm lying to avoid conflict."
- **[Clinical Guidance]:**
 - **Fair:** Be fair to yourself and the other person.
 - **No Apologies:** Don't apologize for having an opinion or for being alive.
 - **Stick to YOUR OWN Values:** Don't sell out your integrity or values just to be liked. Be clear on what you believe is moral.
 - **Truthful:** Don't lie, exaggerate, or act helpless.
- **[Therapist Dialogue]:** "I want you to know that your needs and your values are valid. You don't have to apologize for having a boundary or a preference. It's okay to stand by what you believe in, even if it feels uncomfortable. Let's look at the value that is most important to you here—how can we protect that value while staying truthful?"

When interpersonal skills cannot change an external situation, one must move to regulating the internal emotional response.

5. Module IV: Emotion Regulation and Vulnerability Reduction

While we cannot control emotions completely, we can modulate their intensity. This requires "Checking the Facts" before taking action.

Opposite Action: Changing Unwanted Emotions

- **[Topic]:** Opposite Action Skill: Changing Unwanted Emotions.
- **[Trigger Symptoms]:** Intense fear (when safe), unjustified anger, paralyzing shame, "I want to hide," "I want to lash out."
- **[Clinical Guidance]:**
 - **Check the Facts:** Is my emotion justified by the actual facts of the situation? If the emotion does not fit the facts, proceed to Opposite Action.

- **Identify the Urge:** What is the emotion telling you to do? (e.g., Fear says "Run").
- **Do the Opposite:** Perform the action that contradicts the urge.
 - *Fear (unjustified):* Approach what you fear.
 - *Anger (unjustified):* Gently avoid or show a little kindness.
 - *Shame (unjustified):* Go public with what you are ashamed of.
- **[Therapist Dialogue]:** "I see that you're feeling a really strong urge to pull away and hide right now. I know that feeling can be so heavy. But if we check the facts and see that you are actually safe, then hiding might just keep the pain going. If we want the shame to change, we have to do the opposite of what it's whispering to you. What is one tiny step we can take to stay engaged instead of pulling away?"

ABC PLEASE: Reducing Vulnerability

- **[Topic]:** ABC PLEASE Skills: Reducing Vulnerability to Emotion Mind.
- **[Trigger Symptoms]:** "Fragile," mood-dependent behavior, low resilience, "everything sets me off," "I'm always on edge."
- **[Clinical Guidance]:**
 - **A - Accumulate Positive Emotions:** Do one small pleasant thing today.
 - **B - Build Mastery:** Do one thing that makes you feel competent or effective.
 - **C - Cope Ahead:** Mentally rehearse how you will handle a difficult situation.
 - **PLEASE - Physical Health:**
 - **PL:** Treat Physical illness.
 - **E:** Balanced Eating.
 - **A:** Avoid mood-Altering substances.
 - **S:** Balanced Sleep.
 - **E:** Get Exercise.
- **[Therapist Dialogue]:** "It is so much harder to manage big feelings when our bodies are tired or hungry. I really want to make sure you're taking care of yourself. Taking care of your physical body is one of the kindest ways you can take care of your mind. Have you had a chance to eat something today, or get a little rest? Let's find one small way to build a little 'mastery' or 'positive emotion' into your afternoon."

This structured knowledge base serves as a comprehensive tool for RAG-driven DBT support, ensuring clinical precision is always balanced with therapeutic warmth.